10 Automations Every Small Business Should Have Running Before Lunch

A Practical Playbook for Time-Poor Business Owners Who Are Sick of Doing Manually What Software Should Be Doing Automatically

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> "The first rule of any technology used in a business is that automation applied to an efficient operation will magnify the efficiency. The second is that automation applied to an inefficient operation will magnify the inefficiency." — Bill Gates

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A Note Before We Start

You bought this because something clicked. Maybe it was the tenth time this week you copied a contact from a web form into your CRM. Maybe it was the Friday afternoon you spent manually pulling numbers for a report your accountant needs. Maybe it was the lead that slipped through the cracks because nobody followed up in time.

Whatever it was — you're right. That stuff shouldn't be happening manually. And after this playbook, it won't.

This isn't a theoretical guide. Every automation in here is real, tested, and running inside businesses just like yours right now. Some of them took us 20 minutes to set up. None of them required a developer.

By the end of this playbook, you'll have the knowledge, the recipes, and the exact steps to get at least three of these live before lunch today.

Let's get into it.

Table of Contents

1. Introduction — The 10 Hours a Week You're Wasting (and How to Get Them Back)
2. The Automation Mindset — What to Automate First and Why
3. Tool Overview — n8n vs Zapier vs Make
4. The 10 Automation Recipes
    - Recipe #1: Lead Capture → CRM Entry
    - Recipe #2: New Order → Fulfilment Notification (Shopify)
    - Recipe #3: Weekly Report → Email Delivery
    - Recipe #4: Customer Review Request (Post-Purchase)
    - Recipe #5: Invoice → Payment Reminder Sequence
    - Recipe #6: Social Mention → Team Alert
    - Recipe #7: New Inquiry → Instant Response + Booking Link
    - Recipe #8: Inventory Low → Supplier Email Alert
    - Recipe #9: Monthly P&L Summary → Accountant Delivery
    - Recipe #10: Competitor Price Change → Your Alert
5. How to Build Your First Automation (Non-Technical Walkthrough)
6. Automation Stack by Budget
7. What NOT to Automate
8. Maintenance — Keeping Your Automations Healthy
9. Bonus: Automation Audit Worksheet

10. Next Steps + Free Audit Offer

PART ONE: INTRODUCTION

The 10 Hours a Week You're Wasting (and How to Get Them Back)

Let's be honest about something.

If you run a small business, there's a solid chance you're doing at least a dozen things every week that a piece of software could handle in zero seconds flat. Not because you're lazy or disorganised — but because nobody ever sat you down and showed you the alternative.

The average small business owner wastes **8–12 hours per week** on tasks that are fully automatable. That's one full working day. Every single week. Gone.

Here's what that looks like in the wild:

- You get a lead from your website contact form. You manually open your CRM, create a new contact, copy across the name, email, phone, and note what they enquired about. Five minutes. Every. Single. Lead.
- A customer places an order in your Shopify store. You hop over to your fulfilment system or send a WhatsApp to your warehouse. Two minutes. Per order.
- Friday afternoon rolls around and your manager needs the weekly sales report. You open four tabs, pull numbers from your POS, your Shopify dashboard, and your accounting software, copy them into a spreadsheet, format it, then email it. Forty-five minutes.
- A customer buys something. Two weeks later you remember you should ask them for a Google review. You track down their email. You write a message. Sometimes. When you remember.

Sound familiar? That's your 10 hours.

And here's the thing — it's not just about the time. It's about what happens when humans are in the loop on repetitive tasks:

Humans forget. Software doesn't. Humans get tired. Software doesn't. Humans take holidays. Software doesn't.

Every manual process is a potential point of failure. A lead that didn't get entered. A follow-up that never went out. A supplier who wasn't alerted until stock hit zero.

Automation removes the human from the middle of tasks that don't need a human. You're still running the show — you're just not the one doing the data entry.

What's Actually Possible

The 10 automations in this playbook collectively save the average small business owner **6–12 hours per week**. For a business owner billing $150/hour, that's $900–$1,800 in recovered productive time. Every week.

But even if you don't bill by the hour, reclaiming that time means:

- 📈 More time on strategic work that actually grows your business
- 😌 Less context-switching and mental load
- 🛡️ Fewer things falling through the cracks
- 💬 Faster response times to customers (which drives revenue)
- 🌴 The ability to actually unplug on weekends

This playbook covers 10 automations. You don't have to implement all 10 today. Pick the two or three that make you wince the most — the tasks you resent the most, the things you know you're inconsistent about — and start there.

The rest will follow.

The Automation Reality Check

Before we go further, let's be clear about what automation is and isn't:

Automation IS: - Connecting software tools so they talk to each other automatically - Triggering actions (emails, entries, alerts) based on events - Removing humans from repetitive, rule-based tasks - Making your business more consistent and scalable

Automation IS NOT: - Replacing the relationships and judgment that make your business valuable - A set-and-forget system with zero maintenance (more on this

later) - Complicated or expensive (most of what’s in here is free or near-free) - Only for tech companies (it’s arguably more valuable for traditional businesses)

You don’t need to know how to code. You don’t need a developer. You need this playbook, a free account on one automation platform, and about an hour of your time.

That’s it.

PART TWO: THE AUTOMATION MINDSET

What to Automate First and Why

Not all automation is created equal. Before you start plugging things together, it's worth spending five minutes thinking about what to automate and in what order. Get this right, and you'll save yourself the frustration of automating something that doesn't actually move the needle.

The Four Pillars of a Good Automation Target

A task is worth automating when it ticks at least three of these four boxes:

1. It happens frequently If you do something once a month, manual is fine. If you do it daily, automate it.

2. It follows a consistent pattern "Every time X happens, do Y" is the automation sweet spot. If it requires complex judgment every time, it's not yet ready to automate.

3. It's currently causing problems Dropped leads. Late invoices. Missed follow-ups. If the manual version is failing you, automation is the fix.

4. The stakes of a mistake are high Some manual tasks are low-stakes. But if forgetting a follow-up costs you a $5,000 sale, that's a task worth protecting with automation.

The ROI Framework: Prioritising Your Automation Queue

Before you pick your first automation, run it through this quick calculation. It takes two minutes and tells you which automations deserve your attention first.

STEP 1: CALCULATE TIME COST

> **Time Cost = Minutes per occurrence × Frequency per week × 52 × Hourly rate ÷ 60**

Example: You spend 5 minutes entering leads into your CRM. You get 20 leads per week.

`5 × 20 × 52 × $100 ÷ 60 = $8,667/year`

That's what you're paying (in your time) to do this task manually every year.

STEP 2: CALCULATE ERROR COST

Think about what happens when this process fails. A dropped lead, a missed invoice, an unsent follow-up. Estimate the cost of one failure and multiply by how often it happens.

Example: You lose 2 leads per month because they fell through the cracks. Each lead is worth $500.

`2 × $500 × 12 = $12,000/year in lost revenue`

STEP 3: ADD THEM TOGETHER

Total Annual Cost of Manual Process = Time Cost + Error Cost

In this example: `$8,667 + $12,000 = $20,667/year`

STEP 4: COMPARE TO AUTOMATION COST

Most automations cost between $0 and $50/month to run. That's $0–$600/year.

If the automation saves $20,667 and costs $600 to run, the ROI is obvious.

Automation Priority Matrix

Use this matrix to stack-rank your automation ideas. Rate each task from 1–5 on frequency and pain, then focus on anything that scores 7+.

TASK	FREQUENCY (1–5)	PAIN LEVEL (1–5)	SCORE	PRIORITY
Lead capture to CRM	5	4	9	🔴 High
Weekly reporting	4	5	9	🔴 High
Review requests	3	4	7	🟡 Medium
Inventory alerts	2	5	7	🟡 Medium
Social monitoring	2	2	4	🟢 Low

The Three Automation Layers

As you build out your automation stack, think in three layers:

Layer 1 — Capture Automations These ensure nothing falls through the cracks. Lead forms, inquiry responses, order confirmations. If information enters your business, Layer 1 makes sure it gets to the right place.

Start here. The payoff is immediate and the cost of not having these is high.

Layer 2 — Communication Automations These ensure your customers and team hear from you at exactly the right moment. Review requests, payment reminders, booking confirmations, stock alerts.

Build these second. They directly impact revenue and customer satisfaction.

Layer 3 — Intelligence Automations These aggregate and surface information you'd otherwise have to dig for. Weekly reports, P&L summaries, competitor monitoring.

Build these third. They make you smarter without taking your time.

Most of the 10 recipes in this playbook are Layer 1 or Layer 2. If you implement all 10, you'll have a complete automation stack.

PART THREE: TOOL OVERVIEW

n8n vs Zapier vs Make — Which One Should You Use?

These three platforms are the workhorses of small business automation. Each has strengths and weaknesses, and the right choice depends on your technical comfort level, budget, and how complex your automations are likely to get.

Let’s cut through the noise.

Platform Comparison Table

FEATURE			
Pricing	Free (self-hosted) or $20+/mo (cloud)	Free (limited) or $29.99+/mo	Free (limited) or $9+/mo
Ease of use	Moderate — visual but technical	Very easy — built for beginners	Moderate — visual + more powerful
App integrations	400+	6,000+	1,500+
Custom code	Yes (JavaScript/Python nodes)	Yes (paid plans)	Yes (paid plans)
Data transformation	Excellent	Basic	Excellent
Error handling	Excellent	Limited	Good
Task limits	Unlimited (self-hosted)	100/mo free; 750+ paid	1,000 ops/mo free
Best for	Tech-comfortable users; complex flows	Beginners; simple two-step automations	Intermediate users; data-heavy flows
Self-hosting	✅ Yes (on your own server)	❌ No	❌ No
Multi-step flows	✅ Unlimited	✅ Unlimited (paid)	✅ Unlimited
Parallel branches	✅ Yes	Limited	✅ Yes

FEATURE			
Australian support	Community	Business hours	Business hours

Zapier — The No-Brainer for Beginners

Zapier is the platform most people have heard of, and for good reason. It has the largest library of app integrations (6,000+), the friendliest interface, and the best documentation for beginners.

Use Zapier if: - You're new to automation and want to learn without friction - You're connecting mainstream apps (Gmail, HubSpot, Shopify, Slack, etc.) - You don't have complex data transformation needs - You want to move fast and don't want to manage infrastructure

Watch out for: - Costs can escalate quickly as you add more Zaps and task volume - The free plan (100 tasks/month) is gone in a day for most businesses - Less flexibility for complex multi-branch logic

Pricing reality check: For the 10 automations in this playbook, expect to spend $29–$49/month on Zapier once you're running at real volume.

Make (formerly Integromat) — The Sweet Spot

Make sits between Zapier and n8n in terms of complexity and power. It has a visual workflow builder like Zapier, but with far more powerful data handling and branching logic. It's also significantly cheaper than Zapier for equivalent functionality.

Use Make if: - You want more power than Zapier without the complexity of n8n - You need to transform or manipulate data (not just pass it along) - You're building automations with multiple branches or conditional logic - Budget is a consideration (it's meaningfully cheaper than Zapier)

Watch out for: - The interface has a learning curve — it's not as intuitive as Zapier upfront - Fewer native integrations than Zapier (though still 1,500+, which covers most SMB needs) - "Operations" pricing model can be confusing at first

Pricing reality check: The free plan (1,000 operations/month) will cover simple automations. For all 10 in this playbook running at volume, budget $29–$49/month.

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n8n — The Power User's Choice

n8n is open-source and can be self-hosted on your own server for essentially zero ongoing cost. It's the most technically flexible of the three and has become enormously popular in the last two years as a Zapier alternative for teams who've outgrown the basics.

Use n8n if: - You're comfortable with technical concepts (JSON, APIs, etc.) or have someone who is - You want to self-host and keep data on your own infrastructure - Your automations are complex or involve custom code - You want unlimited workflows with no per-task pricing - You're building for scale and don't want to be limited by a SaaS pricing model

Watch out for: - Self-hosting requires a server (even a cheap $5/month VPS works, but it's a setup step) - The cloud version is excellent but priced similarly to competitors - Fewer beginner-friendly tutorials compared to Zapier - Some integrations require more manual configuration

Pricing reality check: Self-hosted n8n is free forever (you pay for the server, ~$5–10/month). n8n Cloud starts at $20/month.

So Which One Should You Pick?

Here's the honest answer:

> **If you've never done automation before → Start with Zapier.** Get your first few wins. Learn the concepts. Don't fight the tooling.

> **If you've played with Zapier and want more power → Move to Make.** It's cheaper, more capable, and the learning curve pays off fast.

> **If you have a technical co-founder, IT person, or you're comfortable in a terminal → Try n8n.** Self-host it, pay nothing, and never worry about task limits again.

For the recipes in this playbook, we'll use **platform-agnostic instructions** with notes on where each platform handles things differently. The logic is the same regardless of which tool you use — only the interface changes.

A Note on AI-Powered Automation

All three platforms now have AI features built in. Zapier has "AI Actions," Make has AI modules, and n8n has native OpenAI/Anthropic integrations that are genuinely excellent.

You don't need AI to implement the 10 recipes in this playbook. But as a next step, each of these platforms can now draft emails, summarise data, categorise leads, and make decisions — all without you touching a keyboard.

We'll flag where AI can supercharge individual recipes throughout the playbook.

PART FOUR: THE 10 AUTOMATION RECIPES

📥 Recipe #1: Lead Capture → CRM Entry

Never Lose a Lead Again

⏱️ **Time Saved:** 3–7 minutes per lead 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐☆☆☆☆ (Beginner) 📦 **Category:** Capture Automation (Layer 1) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** $5,000–$20,000+ (depending on lead volume and value)

What It Does

Every time someone fills out a form on your website — a contact form, an enquiry form, a quote request form — their details automatically appear in your CRM as a new contact or lead. No copying. No pasting. No forgetting.

The automation also: - Tags the lead with the source (e.g., “Website Contact Form”) - Sets a follow-up task or reminder for your sales person - Optionally sends an immediate “We got your message” email to the prospect - Notifies you or your team via Slack/email that a new lead has arrived

This is the single most impactful automation for most small businesses. Leads are the lifeblood of your business. Losing even one because of manual process failure is unacceptable.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Website form tool	Capture lead info	Usually free (Gravity Forms, Typeform, Google Forms, WPForms)
CRM	Store and manage leads	Free–$50/mo (HubSpot free, Pipedrive, Salesforce)
Automation platform	Connect them	Free–$29/mo (Zapier, Make, n8n)
Email tool (optional)	Send auto-response	Often included in CRM

Most common combos: - WordPress + Gravity Forms → HubSpot CRM (all free to start) - Typeform → Pipedrive (Typeform has Zapier integration built in) - Any form → Google Sheets (if you're not on a CRM yet, this works fine)

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Set Up Your Trigger

In your automation platform, create a new workflow and set the trigger to your form tool.

- **Zapier:** Search for your form app, select "New Form Submission" as the trigger
- **Make:** Choose your form module, set trigger to "Watch Responses"
- **n8n:** Use the Webhook node or the specific app node for your form tool

Test the trigger by submitting a test form. Confirm the platform is receiving the data.

Step 2: Map the Fields

You'll see the data from your form come through as variables: - `{{name}}` - `{{email}}` - `{{phone}}` - `{{message}}` - `{{form_source}}`

Note which fields you have. You'll map these to your CRM in the next step.

Step 3: Create the CRM Action

Add an action step to your automation:

- **If using HubSpot:** Select "Create Contact," map `{{email}}` to the Email field, `{{name}}` to Full Name, etc.
- **If using Pipedrive:** Select "Create Person," then "Create Deal" linked to that person
- **If using Google Sheets:** Select "Append Row," map each field to the appropriate column

> 💡 **Pro tip:** Always map the form submission date/time as well. Knowing when a lead came in is valuable for tracking response times.

Step 4: Add a Tag or Label

In your CRM action, add a tag or label that marks where this lead came from: - "Website — Contact Form" - "Website — Quote Request" - "Facebook Lead Form"

This is gold for marketing attribution later. Takes 10 seconds to set up now.

Step 5: Set a Follow-Up Task (Optional but Recommended)

Add a second action: create a task in your CRM assigned to the relevant salesperson.

Task details: - **Title:** "Follow up with [lead name]" - **Due date:** Today + 1 hour (or same business day) - **Assigned to:** Your name, or the relevant team member

Step 6: Send Confirmation Email (Optional)

Add another action to send an auto-reply to the lead.

Template:

```
Subject: We've received your enquiry — [Your Business Name]

Hi [name],
```

```
Thanks for reaching out! We've received your enquiry and one of our team
will be in touch within [X hours/1 business day].

In the meantime, feel free to browse [resource/FAQ/portfolio link].

Speak soon,
[Your name]
[Your business]
```

This one step can dramatically improve prospect experience. Most competitors don't send this. You just differentiated.

Step 7: Test It

Submit a test form. Confirm: - ✅ Contact appears in CRM within 30 seconds - ✅ Tags/labels applied correctly - ✅ Follow-up task created - ✅ Auto-reply received in your test inbox

Step 8: Turn It On

Activate the automation. You're done. This now runs forever, for every lead, without you touching it.

🔧 Troubleshooting Tips

- **Duplicate contacts:** Most CRMs can be set to "update if exists, create if not." Use this setting to avoid duplicate entries when the same person submits multiple times.
- **Missing fields:** If a field isn't coming through, check that your form has that field enabled and that it's mapped correctly in the automation.
- **Spam submissions:** Add a filter step in your automation to check if the email field contains "@" — this blocks most bot submissions from creating junk CRM entries.

🤖 AI Enhancement

Once this is running, you can add an AI step (OpenAI or Claude via n8n/Make) to: - Analyse the message and automatically score the lead (hot/warm/cold) - Categorise the enquiry type - Draft a personalised initial response based on what they wrote

This turns a basic automation into a mini sales assistant.

📦 Recipe #2: New Order → Fulfilment Notification

Shopify Orders Into Action Without You as the Middle Man

⏱️ **Time Saved:** 2–5 minutes per order 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐☆☆☆☆ (Beginner) 📦 **Category:** Capture Automation (Layer 1) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** $2,000–$15,000 (at 10–50 orders/day)

What It Does

The moment a new order is placed in Shopify, a notification goes automatically to whoever needs to act on it — your warehouse, your supplier, your fulfilment partner, or your Slack channel. No manual forwarding. No “did you see that order?” conversations.

The notification includes all the relevant order details: - Order number and date - Customer name and address - Products ordered (with SKUs and quantities) - Any special instructions or notes - Shipping method selected

Depending on your setup, this can also: - Create a pick slip or packing slip automatically - Update a fulfilment spreadsheet - Trigger a fulfilment platform (like

ShipStation or Australia Post MyPost Business) - Send an SMS to your driver or courier

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What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Shopify	Your online store	$39+/mo
Email or Slack	Receive notifications	Free
Automation platform	Connect them	Free–$29/mo
Fulfilment platform (optional)	Process orders	Varies

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Set Up Your Shopify Trigger

In your automation platform, create a new workflow:

- **Trigger:** Shopify → "New Order"
- Connect your Shopify account (you'll need your store URL and API credentials — the platform will walk you through this)

Test by placing a test order (you can do $0 test orders in Shopify's development mode).

Step 2: Format the Order Message

Add a data formatting step to create a clean, readable message. Here's a template:

```
🛒 NEW ORDER — #{{order_number}}

Customer: {{customer.first_name}} {{customer.last_name}}
Email: {{customer.email}}
Phone: {{customer.phone}}

Ship to:
```

```
{{shipping_address.address1}}
{{shipping_address.city}}, {{shipping_address.province}}
{{shipping_address.zip}}

Items:
{{#each line_items}}
- {{quantity}}x {{title}} (SKU: {{sku}})
{{/each}}

Total: ${{total_price}}
Shipping: {{shipping_lines.title}}

Notes: {{note}}
```

> 💡 **Pro tip:** Most automation platforms let you loop through the line items array so every product in the order shows up in the message. This is worth the extra 5 minutes to configure.

Step 3: Choose Your Notification Destination

Option A — Email to fulfilment team: - Action: Send Email - To: warehouse@yourbusiness.com.au (or your fulfilment partner's email) - Subject: `New Order #{{order_number}} — Action Required` - Body: Your formatted message above

Option B — Slack notification: - Action: Slack → Post Message - Channel: #orders or #fulfilment - Message: Your formatted message

Option C — Google Sheets log: - Action: Google Sheets → Append Row - Map: Order number, date, customer name, items, total, status

Option D — Multiple destinations: Add multiple action steps to notify via email AND log to a spreadsheet AND post to Slack. All from a single trigger.

Step 4: Add a Filter for Specific Conditions (Optional)

If you only want notifications for certain types of orders: - Orders over $X value - Orders with specific products (e.g., custom/made-to-order items) - Orders with express shipping selected

Add a filter/condition step before your notification actions.

Step 5: Tag Processed Orders

Add a final action to tag the order in Shopify as “Notified” or “Fulfilment Triggered.” This gives you visibility into which orders have been actioned.

Step 6: Test and Activate

Place a test order. Confirm the notification arrives with correct details. Activate.

🔧 Advanced Variations

For businesses using 3PL (third-party logistics): Most 3PLs accept order feeds via email or API. Set up the email notification action to send to your 3PL’s intake email in their required format.

For businesses with a local driver: Add an action to send an SMS via Twilio or MessageBird with the delivery address and order details. Your driver gets a ping the moment the order is placed.

For made-to-order or custom products: Add a step to create a task in your project management tool (Trello, Asana, ClickUp) with the order details and a due date based on your production time.

📊 Recipe #3: Weekly Report → Email Delivery

Zero Manual Work on the Report Your Team Actually Reads

⏱️ **Time Saved:** 30–90 minutes per week 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐⭐☆☆ (Intermediate) 📦 **Category:** Intelligence Automation (Layer 3) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** $3,000–$10,000

What It Does

Every Monday morning (or Friday afternoon, or whatever timing works for you), an automated report lands in your inbox — or your team's — with last week's key numbers. Sales. Orders. Revenue. New customers. Whatever you track.

No one pulled those numbers manually. No one spent Friday afternoon in four browser tabs. The automation ran at 7am, pulled the data, formatted it, and sent it. By the time you're drinking your first coffee, the report is already in your inbox.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Your data source	Where the numbers live (Shopify, Xero, Google Analytics, etc.)	Existing subscription
Google Sheets (optional)	Intermediate data storage/ formatting	Free
Email tool	Deliver the report	Free (Gmail)
Automation platform	Orchestrate the whole thing	$0–$29/mo

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Define Your Report Contents

Before you build anything, write down exactly what goes in the report. Keep it to 5–10 metrics max. More than that and nobody reads it.

Example report structure:

```
📊 WEEKLY BUSINESS SNAPSHOT — Week of [date]

Revenue: $X (vs $X last week — ↑/↓ X%)
Orders: X
New Customers: X
```

```
Avg Order Value: $X

Top Product: [Product name] — X units sold
Worst Performer: [Product name] — X units sold

Outstanding Invoices: $X (X invoices)
Bank Balance: $X
```

Step 2: Identify Your Data Sources

Map where each metric comes from: - Revenue, Orders, AOV → Shopify, WooCommerce, or your POS - New Customers → CRM or your store - Outstanding Invoices → Xero, MYOB, or QuickBooks - Bank Balance → Xero bank feeds

Step 3: Set Up Data Pulls

For each data source, add a "Get Data" step in your automation.

For Shopify (revenue this week): - Action: Shopify → Search Orders - Filter: Created at >= 7 days ago - Aggregate: Sum of `total_price`

For Xero (outstanding invoices): - Action: Xero → List Invoices - Filter: Status = "AUTHORISED" (unpaid) - Aggregate: Sum of `AmountDue`

For Google Analytics (website visits): - Action: Google Analytics → Run Report - Dimensions: Date range (last 7 days) - Metrics: Sessions, Users

> 💡 **The Google Sheets Trick:** If your automation platform struggles to pull data directly from your tools, use a scheduled Google Apps Script to pull data into a Google Sheet first. Then your automation just reads from the sheet. This works 100% of the time and is much more reliable.

Step 4: Build the Email

Create an "Send Email" action with a clean HTML or text template. Here's a simple text version:

```
Subject: 📊 Weekly Report — [Business Name] | Week of [date]

G'day [name],

Here's your weekly snapshot:
```

```
REVENUE & ORDERS
Revenue: ${{total_revenue}}
Orders: {{total_orders}}
New Customers: {{new_customers}}
Avg Order Value: ${{aov}}

FINANCE
Outstanding Invoices: ${{outstanding_invoices}} ({{invoice_count}} invoices)
Overdue (30+ days): ${{overdue_invoices}}

HIGHLIGHTS
Best selling product: {{top_product}} ({{top_product_units}} units)

See full detail: [link to your dashboard or Shopify/Xero]

—
This report was generated automatically by your business automation stack.
```

Step 5: Schedule the Automation

Set the automation to run on a schedule:

- **Zapier:** Add a “Schedule by Zapier” trigger, set to Weekly on Monday at 7:00 AM
- **Make:** Set the schedule trigger to “Every week” on Monday 07:00
- **n8n:** Use the Cron node: `0 7 * * 1` (7am every Monday)

Step 6: Test It

Trigger the automation manually. Check that all data pulls correctly and the email looks right. Fix any field mapping issues. Then activate.

🔧 Troubleshooting Tips

- **Date range issues:** Automation platforms handle “last 7 days” differently. Test with specific hard-coded dates first, then switch to dynamic date calculations.
- **Number formatting:** Raw API data often comes back as `12345.67`. Add a formatter step to convert to `$12,345.67`.
- **Missing data:** Add error handling — if a data pull fails, have the automation send a “Report incomplete — [source] data missing” notification rather than silently failing.

🤖 AI Enhancement

Add a GPT/Claude step after the data pull and before the email. Feed the AI the raw numbers and ask it to: - Write a one-paragraph “week in review” narrative - Flag any anomalies (revenue down >20% week-on-week) - Suggest one action based on the data

Now your report doesn’t just show numbers — it tells you what to do about them.

⭐ Recipe #4: Customer Review Request

Timed, Automatic, Every Single Customer — Without You Lifting a Finger

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⏱️ **Time Saved:** 5–10 minutes per follow-up (multiply by customer volume) 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐☆☆☆ (Easy-Intermediate) 📦 **Category:** Communication Automation (Layer 2) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** Incalculable — reviews drive 30–40% of new customer decisions

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What It Does

A set number of days after a customer makes a purchase (7 days for physical products, 1–2 days for services), they automatically receive a personalised email asking for a review. The email links directly to your Google Business profile, Trustpilot page, or product review section.

No manual tracking. No awkward follow-up calls. No leaving it until you remember and it’s been six weeks.

The timing is everything here. Hit a customer 7 days after delivery and their experience is fresh, the product is in use, and they're most likely to write something positive and detailed. Too soon, and they haven't had time to form an opinion. Too late, and they've moved on.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Shopify/ WooCommerce	Order trigger	Existing subscription
Email service	Send the request	Free–$30/mo (Mailchimp, Klaviyo, or even Gmail via automation)
Review platform	Where they leave the review	Free (Google, Trustpilot, ProductReview.com.au)
Automation platform	Connect and delay	Free–$29/mo

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Set Up the Order Trigger

- Trigger: Shopify/WooCommerce → "Order Fulfilled" (not "Order Created" — you want to confirm delivery first)
- For service businesses: trigger from your booking/CRM tool when a job is marked "Complete"

Step 2: Add a Delay

This is the key step. Add a "Wait/Delay" step before the email action.

- **For physical products:** 7 days (allows for delivery + a few days of use)
- **For fast-delivery products (same-day):** 2–3 days

- **For services:** 1 day after job completion
- **For software/digital products:** 3 days after purchase

In Zapier: Use “Delay by Zapier” — “Delay For” → 7 days In Make: Use the “Sleep” module In n8n: Use the “Wait” node

Step 3: Write the Email

This email needs to feel personal, not automated. Here’s a template that converts well:

```
Subject: How did we go, [first name]? 😊

Hi [first name],

Hope you're loving your [product name]!

We're a small team, and honestly, reviews mean the world to us.
If you've got 2 minutes, we'd love to hear what you thought —
it helps other customers like you make the right choice.

[⭐ Leave us a review here]
(That's a direct link — takes about 90 seconds.)

If anything wasn't right, please hit reply and let me know directly.
We'd love to make it right before you leave a review.

Cheers,
[Your name]
[Business name]
```

> 💡 **The “Hit Reply” line is magic.** It intercepts unhappy customers before they leave a negative review. You’ll be amazed how many people reply to sort out issues privately when given the chance.

Step 4: Add a Filter for Refunded Orders

Before the email action, add a condition:

- If order status = “Refunded” → Skip the email
- If customer has already left a review → Skip (requires CRM tag check)

Nothing damages trust like asking for a review from someone who returned the product.

Step 5: Add the Review Link

Your Google Business review link looks like this: `https://search.google.com/local/writereview?placeid=YOUR_PLACE_ID`

Find your Place ID at: developers.google.com/maps/documentation/places/web-service/place-id

For Trustpilot: `https://www.trustpilot.com/evaluate/yourdomain.com.au`

Step 6: Track Responses (Optional)

Add a UTM parameter to your review link so you can track which emails drove reviews: `https://search.google.com/local/writereview?placeid=XXXX&utm_source=automation&utm_medium=email`

Step 7: Test and Activate

Create a test order. Confirm the delay triggers correctly (you can temporarily set it to 5 minutes for testing). Check the email arrives with correct personalisation. Activate.

📈 Expected Results

Businesses that implement automated review requests typically see: - **3–8% review rate** from automated emails (vs 1–2% from manual/no follow-up) - **40–60% increase** in review volume within 3 months - Significant improvement in Google ranking for local search

At 100 customers/month, that's potentially 3–8 new reviews per month — on autopilot.

💳 Recipe #5: Invoice → Payment Reminder Sequence

Get Paid Faster Without Awkward Conversations

⏱️ **Time Saved:** 10–20 minutes per overdue invoice 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐☆☆☆ (Easy-Intermediate) 📦 **Category:** Communication Automation (Layer 2) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** Directly proportional to your outstanding receivables

---

What It Does

When an invoice isn't paid by its due date, a sequence of polite, professional payment reminders goes out automatically — at 1 day overdue, 7 days overdue, and 14 days overdue. Each reminder escalates slightly in tone and urgency.

No more awkward "just checking in" emails you've been avoiding for two weeks. No more cash flow surprises because you forgot to chase that invoice. The automation handles it for you, professionally, every time.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Xero / MYOB / QuickBooks	Invoice management	$15–$50/mo
Email service	Send reminders	Free (Gmail) or your platform
Automation platform	Orchestrate the sequence	Free–$29/mo

> 💡 **Note:** Xero, MYOB, and QuickBooks all have built-in payment reminder features. If yours does, use those first — they're simpler. This recipe is for businesses that need more control over timing, tone, or want to connect to other systems (like their CRM or Slack).

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Set Up the Invoice Trigger

In your automation platform: - Connect your accounting software (Xero, MYOB, QB) - Trigger: "Invoice overdue" OR "Invoice Due Date Passed and Status = Unpaid"

If your platform doesn't support "overdue" as a trigger directly, use a scheduled automation that runs daily and checks for unpaid invoices with `due_date < today`.

Step 2: Build the 3-Email Sequence

Email 1 — Day 1 Overdue (Gentle Reminder)

```
Subject: Invoice #[number] – Just a quick reminder

Hi [client name],

I hope you're well. Just a quick heads-up that Invoice #[number]
for $[amount] was due on [date].

This may have slipped through the cracks – if so, no worries!
Here's the invoice link for easy reference: [link]

Happy to answer any questions if anything looks off.

Cheers,
[Your name]
```

Email 2 — Day 7 Overdue (Firm but Professional)

```
Subject: Invoice #[number] – Payment now 7 days overdue

Hi [client name],
```

```
Following up on my previous message — Invoice #[number] for $[amount]
is now 7 days past its due date of [date].

Could you please arrange payment at your earliest convenience?
You can pay via [payment method/link].

If there's a problem or query with this invoice, please get in touch
so we can resolve it quickly.

Invoice link: [link]

Kind regards,
[Your name]
```

Email 3 — Day 14 Overdue (Urgent)

```
Subject: Urgent: Invoice #[number] — 14 Days Overdue

Hi [client name],

Invoice #[number] for $[amount] is now 14 days overdue.
This requires your immediate attention.

Please make payment today via [payment method/link], or contact me
immediately to discuss the account.

If payment is not received within 7 days, I may need to refer this
to our collections process.

Invoice link: [link]

[Your name]
```

Step 3: Add Delays Between Emails

Structure: 1. Invoice trigger → Email 1 (immediately on day 1 overdue) 2. Wait 6 days → Email 2 (day 7 overdue) 3. Wait 7 more days → Email 3 (day 14 overdue) 4. Wait 7 more days → Internal alert to you (day 21 — escalate manually)

Step 4: Add a Stop Condition

Critically, you need to stop the sequence when the invoice is paid. Add a check before each email:

- Check invoice status in your accounting system
- If status = “Paid” → End the workflow (don’t send the email)

This is the most important step. Nobody wants a payment reminder after they’ve already paid.

Step 5: Add Internal Notifications

For Email 3, also send yourself or your bookkeeper a Slack/email alert: “Invoice #[number] is 14 days overdue. Manual follow-up may be required.”

Step 6: Test

Create a test invoice, mark it overdue, and step through the sequence manually. Confirm stop conditions work. Activate.

💡 Power Move: Add a Payment Link

If you use Stripe, Square, or Xero’s online payments, add a direct “Pay Now” button to each reminder email. One click from invoice to paid. Businesses that do this reduce their average payment time by 40–60%.

📣 Recipe #6: Social Mention → Team Alert

Know Every Time Your Brand is Mentioned Online

⏱️ **Time Saved:** 30–60 minutes per week of manual monitoring 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐⭐☆☆ (Intermediate) 📦 **Category:** Intelligence Automation (Layer 3) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** Reputation protection + customer rescue opportunities

---

What It Does

Any time your business is mentioned on social media, review sites, news sites, or across the web — you get an instant notification. A Slack message, an email, or a push to your phone.

This means you can: - Respond to complaints before they go viral - Thank happy customers publicly and quickly - Jump on media opportunities before they go cold - Keep an eye on what competitors are saying about you (or what people are saying about them)

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Mention.com or Google Alerts	Monitor brand mentions	Free–$29/mo
RSS feed or webhooks	Data from monitoring tool	Free
Slack or Email	Receive alerts	Free
Automation platform	Connect and filter	Free–$29/mo

Step-by-Step Setup

Option A: Free Setup with Google Alerts + Make/Zapier

Google Alerts is free and covers web mentions (news articles, blog posts, etc.). It's not real-time for social, but it covers a lot of ground.

1. Go to google.com/alerts
2. Create alerts for:
    - Your business name (exact match in quotes): `"Ignition Agency"`
    - Your business name without quotes: `Ignition Agency`
    - Your personal name: `"Your Name"`

    - Common misspellings of your business name
3. Set delivery to: “As it happens” and “All results”
4. Set email to: the email connected to your automation platform

Then in your automation platform: - Trigger: Gmail → New Email from `googlealerts-noreply@google.com` - Action: Post to Slack channel `#brand-mentions` - Include: Subject line + email body summary

Option B: RSS-Based Setup (Most Reliable)

Google Alerts can also deliver results via RSS feed. This is cleaner:

1. Create your Google Alert
2. Change delivery to RSS feed, copy the RSS URL
3. In your automation platform:
    - Trigger: RSS feed → New Item
    - Filter: Only pass through items containing your business name
    - Action: Slack/email with title, URL, and excerpt

Option C: Mention.com or Brand24 (Paid but Powerful)

For businesses that need real-time social monitoring (Twitter/X, Instagram, Reddit, TikTok), paid tools like Mention.com ($29/mo) or Brand24 ($39/mo) are worth it.

Both have native integrations with Zapier and Make. Set up: - Trigger: New mention in Mention.com - Filter: Sentiment = Negative (prioritise these) - Action: Urgent Slack alert with full mention text + link

Step 3: Add Smart Filtering

Not every mention needs the same level of urgency. Add conditional logic:

```
IF mention contains ["complaint", "angry", "furious", "scam", "avoid",
"terrible", "worst"]
  → Send urgent Slack alert to #team channel + ping @here

ELSE IF mention contains ["love", "great", "amazing", "recommend", "5 stars"]
  → Send to #wins channel (celebrate the positive)

ELSE
  → Log to spreadsheet (low priority monitoring)
```

Step 4: Add a “Mark as Reviewed” Step (Optional)

If using Slack, you can use a Slack button workflow to mark mentions as “reviewed” once someone has actioned them. This prevents the same mention being actioned by two team members.

📱 Social Platform-Specific Tips

- **Instagram mentions:** These need a third-party tool like Mention.com or Agorapulse to monitor. Instagram’s API doesn’t support this natively.
- **Google Reviews:** Use Zapier’s Google My Business integration or a tool like GatherUp to trigger alerts when new reviews are posted.
- **Facebook:** Facebook has a native notification system, but the API is restrictive. Manual monitoring is often still needed here.
- **Reddit:** Use Reddit’s RSS feeds for subreddit mentions. Extremely underrated for businesses in niche industries.

📅 Recipe #7: New Inquiry → Instant Response + Calendar Booking Link

Respond in Seconds. Book Meetings on Autopilot.

⏱️ **Time Saved:** 5–15 minutes per inquiry 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐☆☆☆ (Easy-Intermediate) 📦 **Category:** Communication Automation (Layer 2) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** Speed-to-respond wins more deals than almost anything else*

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*Harvard Business Review study: Responding to a lead within 5 minutes makes you 9x more likely to convert them than responding after 10 minutes.

What It Does

The moment someone sends an inquiry (via form, email, Facebook, or Instagram DM), they receive an automatic response within 60 seconds. This response:

1. Confirms you've received their enquiry
2. Sets expectations on when they'll hear back
3. Includes your calendar booking link so they can self-schedule a call right now, while they're interested

This automation bridges the gap between "they enquired" and "they booked a call" — which is typically the longest, leakiest part of the sales pipeline.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Contact form / email / social inbox	Capture inquiry	Free
Calendly / Cal.com / TidyCal	Booking tool	Free–$12/mo
Email service	Send auto-response	Free
Automation platform	Connect them	Free–$29/mo

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Set Up Your Booking Tool

If you don't have one already, set up Calendly (free) or Cal.com (free, open-source):

1. Connect your Google/Outlook calendar

2. Create an “Initial Consultation” or “Discovery Call” meeting type
3. Set your availability windows (e.g., Mon–Fri, 9am–5pm AEST)
4. Set meeting duration (15 or 30 minutes works best for first calls)
5. Copy your booking link: `https://calendly.com/yourname/discovery`

Step 2: Connect Your Inquiry Source

- **If inquiries come via website form:** Use the same trigger from Recipe #1
- **If inquiries come via email:** Trigger on new emails to your enquiries inbox
- **If via Facebook Lead Forms:** Use Zapier/Make’s Facebook Leads integration

Step 3: Write Your Auto-Response

```
Subject: Got your message — here's how to book a time with us ✅

Hi [name],

Thanks for reaching out to [Business Name]!

I've received your enquiry and I'll be in touch personally within
[X business hours/1 business day].

In the meantime, if you'd like to lock in a quick chat sooner,
you can grab a time directly in my calendar here:

👉 [Book a 30-minute call: calendly.com/yourname/discovery]

No prep needed — just come with your questions.

Talk soon,
[Your name]
[Phone] | [Website]
```

Step 4: Add to CRM

Simultaneously with the email, add the inquiry to your CRM (as per Recipe #1) so it’s tracked.

Step 5: Set Up Booking Confirmation

In Calendly (or your booking tool), configure: - Confirmation email to the prospect (automatic via Calendly) - Reminder emails: 24 hours before + 1 hour before - Add

to your calendar automatically - Notify your team Slack when a new booking is made (Calendly has a native Zapier trigger)

Step 6: Test the Full Flow

Submit a test inquiry. Confirm: - ✅ Auto-response arrives within 60 seconds - ✅ CRM entry created - ✅ Booking link works and calendar is available - ✅ Booking confirmation goes to both parties

---

📊 Conversion Impact

Businesses that add a booking link to their auto-response typically see: - **15–25% of enquirers self-book** without needing a manual follow-up call - **Significantly shorter sales cycle** (less phone tag) - **Higher quality leads** — people who book are more committed

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📦 Recipe #8: Inventory Low → Supplier Email Alert

Never Run Out of Stock Again

⏱️ **Time Saved:** Hours of reactive panic + lost sales from stockouts 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐⭐☆☆ (Intermediate) 📦 **Category:** Capture Automation (Layer 1) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** Cost of one major stockout event (often $5,000–$50,000+)

What It Does

When any product in your Shopify or inventory system drops below your defined reorder threshold, your supplier automatically receives a templated purchase order

email — and you get a Slack notification to approve or cancel before it's sent (optional), or it can go fully automatically.

No more discovering on a Monday morning that your best-selling product is at zero units. No more emergency freight charges. No more "sorry, we're out of stock" to customers who'll never come back.

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Shopify / DEAR Inventory / Cin7	Inventory tracking	Existing
Supplier email	Receive PO	Free
Email service	Send PO	Free
Automation platform	Trigger + send	Free–$29/mo

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Set Your Reorder Points

Before anything else, set reorder points for your key products in Shopify:

1. Go to Products → Select product → Inventory tab
2. Enable "Track quantity"
3. Note the SKU and current reorder threshold you want

For example: Widget X → reorder when stock hits 50 units.

Step 2: Set Up the Inventory Trigger

The challenge here: most automation platforms don't have a native "inventory below threshold" trigger. There are two approaches:

Approach A — Scheduled Check (Recommended for Shopify)

Run a scheduled automation (daily at 7am) that: 1. Fetches all products from Shopify 2. Filters for products where `inventory_quantity < reorder_threshold` 3. For each matching product, triggers the alert

This is more reliable than waiting for a real-time trigger.

In Make/n8n: - Trigger: Schedule (daily, 7am) - Action: Shopify → List Products (with inventory) - Filter: `inventory_quantity < [your threshold]` (e.g., 50) - For each product below threshold: proceed to Step 3

Approach B — Real-Time (For DEAR Inventory, Cin7, or TradeGecko)

These purpose-built inventory systems have native webhook support: - Trigger: "Inventory below reorder point" webhook - Direct, real-time, no daily schedule needed

Step 3: Build the Purchase Order Email

```
Subject: Reorder Request — [Product Name] (SKU: [SKU]) — [Your Business Name]

Hi [Supplier Contact Name],

Please find below a reorder request from [Your Business Name].

REORDER DETAILS:
Product: [Product Name]
SKU: [SKU]
Current Stock Level: [current_quantity] units
Requested Order Quantity: [reorder_quantity] units

Delivery address:
[Your business address]

Please confirm receipt of this order and provide an estimated
delivery timeframe.

If you have any questions, please contact [your name] on [phone/email].

Best regards,
[Your name]
[Business Name]
[ABN: XXXXXXXXXX]
```

Step 4: Add Human Approval (Recommended)

Rather than auto-sending purchase orders, add a Slack approval step:

1. Post to Slack: "⚠️ Low Stock Alert: Widget X is at 48 units (threshold: 50). Send reorder to ABC Supplier? [Approve] [Skip]"
2. If Approved within 2 hours → Send the email
3. If no response → Send a reminder + send the email automatically

This gives you oversight without requiring manual initiation.

Step 5: Log the Reorder

Add a step to log every reorder alert to a Google Sheet: - Date, Product, SKU, Stock level, Alert sent, PO sent (Y/N)

This creates an audit trail and helps you refine your reorder points over time.

📦 Multi-Supplier Handling

If different products come from different suppliers, add a lookup step: 1. When a product triggers the alert, look up the supplier from a Google Sheet or Airtable "supplier directory" 2. Send the email to that supplier's address 3. Use that supplier's name in the email template

This makes the automation work across your entire product range.

📒 Recipe #9: Monthly P&L Summary → Accountant Delivery

Your Accountant Gets the Numbers. Without You Playing Messenger.

⏱️ **Time Saved:** 1–3 hours per month 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐⭐☆☆ (Intermediate) 📦 **Category:** Intelligence Automation (Layer 3) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** $500–$2,000 (in accountant time you avoid paying for)

What It Does

On the last day of each month (or the first of the new month), your accounting software automatically generates a P&L summary and delivers it to your accountant, bookkeeper, or CFO. No chasing. No “can you send me last month’s numbers?” No delays in end-of-month processing.

The report includes: - Total income (by category) - Total expenses (by category) - Net profit/loss - GST collected / GST paid - Any flagged items needing review

---

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Xero / MYOB / QuickBooks	Accounting data	Existing
Email service	Deliver report	Free
Automation platform	Schedule + pull	Free–$29/mo
Google Sheets (optional)	Format report	Free

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Check Your Accounting Software’s Built-In Reporting

Before building a custom automation, check what your accounting software already does:

- **Xero:** Xero has “Report Schedules” that can auto-email reports to specified addresses. Check Reports → Schedule. This may be all you need.

- **MYOB:** Similar scheduled reports available in the Reports section.
- **QuickBooks:** Reports can be scheduled under Reports → Custom Reports.

If your software has this feature, use it. It's faster and more accurate than a third-party automation.

If you need more customisation (different recipients, additional context, format changes), proceed with the automation build.

Step 2: Set Up the Monthly Schedule

- **Zapier:** Schedule trigger → Monthly, on last day of month at 5pm
- **Make:** Schedule → Every month, day = last
- **n8n:** Cron node: `0 17 L * *` (5pm on the last day of every month)

Step 3: Pull the P&L Data from Your Accounting System

Xero example: - Action: Xero → Get Profit and Loss Report - Parameters: Date range = First day of current month to last day of current month

Note: Xero's API returns line-item data in JSON format. You'll need a formatter step to make it readable.

Step 4: Format the Report

Add a formatter step that organises the data into a clean structure.

Alternatively, use a Google Sheet as your template: 1. Create a Google Sheet with your P&L template 2. Use a "Google Sheets → Update Cell" action to fill in each value 3. Then use "Google Sheets → Export as PDF" or send a shareable link

Step 5: Send the Email

```
Subject: [Business Name] — P&L Summary | [Month Year]

Hi [Accountant name],

Please find attached the monthly P&L summary for [Business Name]
for [Month Year].

SUMMARY:
Total Income: $[amount]
Total Expenses: $[amount]
Net Profit/(Loss): $[amount]
GST Collected: $[amount]
```

```
GST Paid: $[amount]

Notes/Items for Review:
[Any flagged items — this can be filled manually or by an AI step]

Full details are available in Xero under [link].

Please let me know if you need anything else.

[Your name / bookkeeper name]
```

Step 6: Add Flagging Logic

Add a simple check before the email: - If net profit is negative: Add "⚠️ LOSS MONTH — please review" to the subject - If any single expense category is >20% higher than previous month: Flag it - If GST liability > $X: Add a reminder about BAS due date

Step 7: Test on the Last Day of the Current Test Month

Manually trigger the automation with last month's dates. Confirm the data is correct. Send to yourself first, then activate for the real end-of-month.

🔍 Recipe #10: Competitor Price Change → Your Alert

Know the Moment Your Competitor Moves. Respond First.

⏱️ **Time Saved:** Hours of manual competitor monitoring per week 💪 **Difficulty:** ⭐⭐⭐⭐☆ (Advanced) 📦 **Category:** Intelligence Automation (Layer 3) 💰 **Estimated Annual Value:** Strategic — hard to quantify, potentially enormous

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What It Does

You define a list of competitors and the specific products or pages you want to monitor. The automation regularly checks those pages and alerts you immediately if the price changes — or if any other content changes on the page.

This gives you: - Early warning when competitors drop prices (so you can respond strategically) - Notice when they add new products or services - Awareness of promotional activity - Intel on what they're changing and when

---

What You Need

TOOL	PURPOSE	COST
Visualping / Distill.io / ChangeTower	Website change monitoring	Free–$14/mo
Automation platform	Receive and route alerts	Free–$29/mo
Slack or Email	Receive notifications	Free

Step-by-Step Setup

Option A: Visualping (Easiest — No-Code)

Visualping.io is the simplest tool for this. It monitors pages visually and sends you an email when it detects changes.

1. Go to visualping.io and create a free account
2. Enter the competitor URL you want to monitor
3. Draw a box around the area you want to monitor (e.g., the price section)
4. Set check frequency: Daily or every 6 hours
5. Set email notification to your email or a dedicated monitoring inbox

The free plan monitors 5 pages every 24 hours. For most SMBs, that's sufficient.

Option B: Distill.io (More Powerful — Browser Extension)

Distill.io lets you select specific page elements (using CSS selectors) rather than visual areas. More precise, but slightly more technical.

1. Install the Distill.io browser extension
2. Navigate to the competitor product page
3. Click the Distill.io extension → "Select element"
4. Click on the price or element you want to monitor
5. Set alert conditions: "When value changes" or "When value drops below $X"
6. Set notification via email or webhook

Option C: Custom n8n/Make Setup (Full Control)

For technical users who want full control and webhook-based integration:

1. Build a scheduled automation (every 6 hours)
2. Action: HTTP GET request to competitor URL
3. Extract price using HTML parsing (the `{{$item.body}}` text, filtered by CSS class or XPath)
4. Compare to stored previous value in a Google Sheet or n8n's static data
5. If changed → Calculate % difference and send Slack alert

This approach is free (beyond the automation platform) and gives you complete control over what you monitor and how you're notified.

Step 4: Build Your Competitor Monitoring List

Create a simple Google Sheet: | Competitor | URL | Current Price | Last Checked | Last Change | |———|——|————|————-|————| | ABC Widgets | https://abc.com/product-x | $49.99 | 2025-06-01 | Never |

Update this sheet automatically as part of your monitoring automation.

Step 5: Configure Slack Alerts

When a price change is detected:

```
🔔 Competitor Price Alert

Competitor: ABC Widgets
Product: Widget X
Previous Price: $49.99
```

```
New Price: $44.99
Change: ↓ 10%
URL: [link]
Detected: 2025-06-15 09:00 AEST

Suggested Action: Review our pricing on this product.
```

Step 6: Add Actionable Routing

In your Slack alert, add buttons: - "🔄 Match Price" — triggers your own pricing update workflow (advanced) - "📊 View Our Price" — links to your own product page - "✅ Acknowledged" — marks alert as reviewed

---

⚠️ Legal and Ethical Note

Monitoring publicly available prices is entirely legal and is a normal business intelligence practice. What you shouldn't do is scrape content at high frequency, circumvent login walls, or access data you're not supposed to have access to.

Stick to publicly available pricing pages and check no more than once every few hours. That's standard practice and completely fine.

PART FIVE: HOW TO BUILD YOUR FIRST AUTOMATION

> ## A Beginner Walkthrough — Even If You've Never Done This Before

Right, if you've made it this far and you're feeling a bit overwhelmed — take a breath. This section is for you. We're going to walk through building your very first automation from scratch, step by step, using Zapier (because it has the gentlest learning curve).

We'll build Recipe #1: Lead Capture → CRM Entry. It's the most impactful and the most beginner-friendly.

By the end of this section, you'll have a live, running automation. Let's go.

What We're Building

Every time someone fills out the contact form on your website, their details automatically appear in HubSpot (free CRM) and you get an email notification.

What you need: - A website with a contact form (we'll use Google Forms as an example — works with any website) - A HubSpot account (free — sign up at hubspot.com) - A Zapier account (free — sign up at zapier.com)

Step 1: Set Up Your Free Accounts

HubSpot (your CRM): 1. Go to hubspot.com and click "Get started free" 2. Sign up with your business email 3. Complete the setup wizard — you'll be at the Contacts

screen in about 5 minutes 4. Note your HubSpot portal ID (it's in the URL when you're logged in)

Zapier (your automation platform): 1. Go to zapier.com and click "Sign up free" 2. Sign up with your business email 3. Skip the onboarding prompts for now

---

Step 2: Create a New Zap

1. In Zapier, click the orange **"+ Create"** button in the top left
2. Click **"Zaps"**
3. You'll see a blank canvas with two boxes: "Trigger" and "Action"

This is the fundamental structure of every automation: > **When [Trigger] happens, do [Action]**

Step 3: Set Up the Trigger (Google Forms)

1. Click the **Trigger** box
2. In the search bar, type "Google Forms"
3. Select **"Google Forms"** from the list
4. For the Event, choose **"New Form Response"**
5. Click **"Sign in to Google Forms"** and connect your Google account
6. Select the form you want to use from the dropdown (or create a test form at forms.google.com first)
7. Click **"Test trigger"** — Zapier will try to find a recent form response to use as test data
8. If no responses exist, go submit your test form now, then come back and click "Test trigger" again

You should now see your test submission data appear — name, email, message, timestamp.

> 💡 **Tip:** The test data is what you'll use to map fields in the next steps. Make sure your test form submission has realistic data (not "test test test").

Step 4: Set Up the Action (HubSpot — Create Contact)

1. Click the **Action** box (or click the "+" button below your trigger)
2. Search for "HubSpot"
3. Select **"HubSpot CRM"**
4. For the Event, choose **"Create or Update Contact"** (this creates a new contact OR updates an existing one if the email already exists — prevents duplicates)
5. Connect your HubSpot account
6. Now you'll see the field mapping screen

Map these fields: - **Email** → Click the field, then select `{{Form Response - Email}}` from your form data - **First Name** → Select `{{Form Response - Name}}` (or split first/last if your form has separate fields) - **Phone** → Select `{{Form Response - Phone}}` (if your form has this) - **Lead Source** → Type "Website Contact Form" (hardcoded — not from the form) - **Message/Notes** → Select `{{Form Response - Message}}`

1. Click **"Continue"**
2. Click **"Test action"** — Zapier will create a test contact in HubSpot using your test data

Go to HubSpot and check: did a new contact appear with the right details? If yes, you're almost done.

Step 5: Add a Second Action (Email Notification to You)

After the HubSpot action, click the **"+"** button to add another action.

1. Search for "Email by Zapier" (this uses Zapier's own email service, no external setup needed)
2. Choose "Send Outbound Email"

3. Fill in:
   - **To:** your-email@yourbusiness.com.au
   - **Subject:** `New Lead: {{Form Response - Name}} from your website`
   - **Body:**

```
New lead received!

Name: {{Form Response - Name}}
Email: {{Form Response - Email}}
Phone: {{Form Response - Phone}}
Message: {{Form Response - Message}}
Time: {{Form Response - Timestamp}}

View in HubSpot: [your HubSpot contacts URL]
```

4. Click **"Continue"** then **"Test action"**
5. Check your inbox — did the notification email arrive?

Step 6: Name and Publish Your Zap

1. Give your Zap a clear name: "Website Contact Form → HubSpot + Email Notification"
2. Click the toggle in the top right to turn it **ON**
3. You'll see it go live

Congratulations. Your first automation is live. 🎉

Step 7: Test It for Real

Go to your website, fill out the contact form for real. Within 1–2 minutes: - ✅ Check HubSpot — new contact should appear - ✅ Check your inbox — notification email should arrive

If both happened, you're done. You've just saved yourself 5 minutes per lead for every lead that ever comes in through your website, forever.

Understanding What You Just Built

Let's take a moment to understand the structure, because this is the foundation for every automation in this playbook:

```
TRIGGER: [Something happens]
         ↓
FILTER:  [Optional: only continue if condition is met]
         ↓
ACTION:  [Do something]
         ↓
ACTION:  [Do something else]
         ↓
ACTION:  [And something else]
```

Every automation follows this pattern. The trigger changes. The actions change. But the logic is always the same.

Now that you understand this, you can build anything in this playbook.

Common Beginner Mistakes (and How to Avoid Them)

Mistake #1: Not testing before activating Always test each step. Don't just assume the field mapping is right — verify it with real data.

Mistake #2: Forgetting error notifications In Zapier, go to Settings → Notifications and enable "Email me when a Zap errors." This way you'll know if something breaks.

Mistake #3: Building too much too fast Start with two steps. Get that working perfectly. Then add more complexity. Don't try to build a 10-step automation on day one.

Mistake #4: Not documenting what you've built Create a simple Google Doc or Notion page that lists all your automations, what they do, when they run, and which accounts they use. You'll thank yourself in 6 months.

Mistake #5: Ignoring the task history Zapier, Make, and n8n all have a "task history" or "run history" page. Check it occasionally. It shows you every automation that ran (or failed). This is your audit trail.

PART SIX: AUTOMATION STACK BY BUDGET

What You Can Build at $0, $100/mo, and $500/mo

Not every business is in the same position. Here's a realistic look at what you can automate at three different budget levels.

💚 The $0 Stack — Free Tools Only

You'd be amazed how much you can automate for absolutely nothing.

Tools: | Tool | What it does | Cost | |——|————-|——| | Zapier (free) | 100 tasks/month, 5 Zaps | $0 | | HubSpot CRM (free) | Full CRM, unlimited contacts | $0 | | Google Forms | Lead capture | $0 | | Gmail | Email notifications + auto-replies | $0 | | Google Sheets | Data logging + reports | $0 | | Calendly (free) | 1 booking page, unlimited meetings | $0 | | Google Alerts | Brand monitoring | $0 | | Mailchimp (free up to 500 contacts) | Email marketing automation | $0 |

What you can automate: - ✅ Recipe #1 (Lead → HubSpot) — with Google Forms + HubSpot free + Zapier free - ✅ Recipe #7 (Inquiry → auto-response + Calendly booking) — fully free - ✅ Recipe #6 (Brand monitoring via Google Alerts) — fully free - ⚠️ Recipe #4 (Review requests) — free via Mailchimp, limited customisation - ❌ Recipe #2, #5, #8, #9 — require paid tools (Shopify, accounting software)

Reality: The $0 stack handles 3–4 of the recipes adequately. If you're just starting out, this is your Day 1 configuration. Spend zero dollars. Get the wins. Upgrade as you scale.

💛 The $100/Month Stack — Small Business Sweet Spot

This is the configuration we recommend for most established small businesses turning over $200K+.

Tools: | Tool | What it does | Cost/mo | |——|————-|———| | Make (Core plan) | Full automation platform, 10,000 ops | $16 | | HubSpot Starter | CRM + email marketing | $20 | | Shopify (Basic) | E-commerce + inventory | $39 | | Xero (Starter) | Accounting | $32 | | Calendly (Standard) | Unlimited booking pages | $12 | | Google Workspace | Gmail + Sheets + Drive | $14 | | **Total** | | **~$133/mo** |

> Adjust based on what you already subscribe to — you're probably already paying for Shopify and Xero.

What you can automate: - ✅ All 10 recipes in this playbook - ✅ Additional automations between all connected tools - ✅ Reliable, professional-grade setup

Reality: This is the sweet spot. For $133/month, you're running a fully automated back-office. The time savings alone (6–12 hours/week) are worth 10–20x this cost at any reasonable hourly rate.

🔴 The $500/Month Stack — Scaling Business

For businesses turning over $1M+ or with teams of 5+ who need advanced automation, AI capabilities, and proper data infrastructure.

Tools: | Tool | What it does | Cost/mo | |——|————-|———| | n8n Cloud (Pro) or Make (Business) | Advanced automation | $50 | | HubSpot Professional | Full CRM + marketing hub | $100 | | Shopify (Standard) | E-commerce | $105 | | Xero (Growing Business) | Accounting | $65 | | Klaviyo (Growth) | Email + SMS marketing automation | $45 | | Slack Pro | Team communication | $8.75/user × 5 = $44 | | Brand24 or Mention.com | Real-time brand monitoring | $39 | | Loom (Business) | Async video for team | $15 | | Notion (Teams) | Documentation + wiki | $16 | | OpenAI API | AI steps in automations | ~$20 | | **Total** | | **~$499/mo** |

What you can automate: - ✅ All 10 recipes + advanced AI versions of each - ✅ Full marketing automation (lead nurturing sequences, abandoned cart, win-back) -

✅ AI-powered lead scoring, report narrative, and decision support - ✅ Team-wide notification routing and approval workflows - ✅ Custom integrations with any API

Reality: At this budget, automation is a core business capability, not just a time-saver. You have a proper stack that can compete with businesses 10x your size.

The Phased Approach

Don't feel pressure to jump to $100 or $500 immediately. Here's a sensible rollout:

Month 1 — Proof of Concept ($0) Pick 2 automations. Implement them on free tools. Measure time savings.

Month 2–3 — Foundation ($50–$80/mo) Add Make or n8n. Connect to your existing Shopify/Xero. Implement 4–6 recipes.

Month 4–6 — Full Stack ($100–$150/mo) Full 10-recipe implementation. Start measuring business impact. Add AI steps.

Month 6+ — Scale and Expand Build custom automations specific to your business. Consider n8n self-hosted if cost is a concern. Explore AI-native workflows.

PART SEVEN: WHAT NOT TO AUTOMATE

The Human Touch Still Matters

There's a temptation, once you've set up a few automations and felt the magic, to automate everything. Resist it.

Some things genuinely should remain human. Getting this wrong doesn't just waste your time — it can damage your relationships, your reputation, and your brand.

Here's your guide to what NOT to automate (and why).

❌ Don't Automate: Complaint Resolution

When a customer is genuinely upset, an automated response makes it worse. Every time.

"Thanks for your feedback! We've received your message and will respond within 2 business days" sent in response to "I waited 6 weeks for my order and it arrived broken" is not just unhelpful — it's infuriating.

Instead: Automate the acknowledgement (so they know you received it), but make sure a human responds personally within hours. Flag complaints as high priority in your CRM and set up immediate notifications so a real person is on it fast.

❌ Don't Automate: Relationship-Critical Communications

Your best clients and partners deserve personal attention. Birthdays, milestone congratulations, project kickoffs, and significant business conversations should come from a human.

Automated birthday emails are instantly recognisable and feel hollow. A genuine personal note — even a brief one — creates real connection.

Instead: Use your CRM to remind you of relationship touchpoints. You get the nudge, you write the personal message.

❌ Don't Automate: Creative and Strategic Decisions

Automation is excellent at moving data and executing defined rules. It's useless at strategy, creativity, and judgment.

Don't automate your pricing decisions, your marketing creative direction, your hiring judgments, or your customer strategy. These need you.

❌ Don't Automate: Anything You Haven't Tested Properly

An untested automation in a critical process (billing, legal communications, customer contracts) is worse than doing it manually. At least manually you notice the mistake.

Run every automation in test mode for at least 5–10 real transactions before trusting it fully. Then audit it monthly.

❌ Don't Automate: Communication Requiring Nuance or Context

Automated invoice reminders work because the rule is simple: invoice unpaid → send reminder. But automating responses to complex customer questions, legal queries, or media enquiries is a recipe for embarrassment.

❌ Don't Automate: When Volume Doesn't Justify It

Automation has a setup cost (time) and a maintenance cost (ongoing attention). If you do something twice a year, doing it manually takes less time than building and maintaining the automation.

Use the ROI Framework from Part 2. If the payback period is longer than 3 months, manual might genuinely be better.

The "Human in the Loop" Pattern

For high-stakes automations, use a "human in the loop" pattern:

1. **Automation prepares the action** (drafts the email, creates the PO, schedules the post)
2. **Human reviews and approves** (one click in Slack or email)
3. **Automation executes** after approval

This gives you the time savings of automation with the safety net of human judgment. It's perfect for: - Purchase orders over a certain value - Customer communications about disputes - Any outgoing communication to new contacts - Financial actions

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The Automation Health Test

Before automating anything, ask these three questions:

1. **"What's the worst thing that could happen if this automation runs with incorrect data?"** If the answer is "significant customer harm," "financial loss," or "legal exposure" — add a human review step.
2. **"Would I be comfortable if this automation ran 1,000 times without me checking it?"** If the answer is no, add more robust error handling and monitoring.

3. **“Does this communication need to feel personal?”** If yes, automate the reminder to yourself to send a personal message. Don’t automate the message itself.

PART EIGHT: MAINTENANCE

Keeping Your Automations Healthy

Set-and-forget is mostly true — but not entirely. Automations need occasional attention. An ignored automation that breaks silently can cause more damage than not having the automation at all.

Here's your maintenance guide.

Why Automations Break

Understanding the common failure points helps you prevent and fix them faster:

1. API/credential changes When you change your Shopify password, update your email, or your automation platform's access token expires, the connection breaks. This is the most common cause of automation failures.

2. App updates When a connected app updates its API (changes field names, deprecates endpoints, adds new required fields), your automation can break without warning.

3. Data format changes If your form adds a new required field, or your Shopify product structure changes, the mapping in your automation may stop working correctly.

4. Plan/subscription changes If you downgrade a tool or let a subscription lapse, the integration may lose access.

5. Rate limits Automation platforms have usage limits. If your business grows significantly, you may hit task/operation limits on your current plan.

Your Monthly Automation Checklist

Do this on the first of every month. It takes 15–20 minutes.

🔴 Critical Checks (every month, no exceptions)

- [ ] Log into your automation platform and check the **task/run history** for errors in the past 30 days
- [ ] Confirm each active automation ran at least once (especially scheduled ones like the weekly report)
- [ ] Test your lead capture automation by submitting a test form
- [ ] Verify CRM entries are still creating correctly
- [ ] Check that payment reminder sequences are running (look for any overdue invoices that should have triggered)

🟡 Important Checks (every month)

- [ ] Review notification emails — are they still arriving? Still formatted correctly?
- [ ] Check for any “authentication required” warnings in your automation platform
- [ ] Verify your booking calendar is still connected and available
- [ ] Check your social mention monitoring — any missed mentions?

🟢 Nice-to-Have Checks (quarterly)

- [ ] Review all automations and ask: “Is this still needed?” Remove any that are no longer relevant
- [ ] Check pricing on all your automation-related subscriptions — are you still on the right plan?
- [ ] Review your reorder thresholds — have your stock requirements changed?
- [ ]

- [ ] Update email templates — are the offers and links still current?
- [ ] Test your P&L automation — does it still pull the right data?

Setting Up Failure Notifications

All major automation platforms can notify you when a Zap/scenario/workflow fails. Set this up on day one.

Zapier: Settings → Notifications → Enable email notifications for Zap errors

Make: Organization settings → Notifications → Enable email for scenario errors

n8n: Settings → Alerts → Configure email or Slack notifications on workflow failure

Set these to notify your main business email (or a dedicated `ops@yourbusiness.com.au` address). Check this inbox at least weekly.

The Automation Documentation Habit

Create a simple "Automation Register" — a Google Doc or Notion page — with one row per automation:

AUTOMATION	PLATFORM	TRIGGER	ACTIONS	CREATED	LAST TESTED	OWNER
Lead Capture	Zapier	Typeform → new submission	HubSpot contact + Email notification	Jan 2025	Feb 2025	Adam
Review Request	Make	Shopify → order fulfilled	7-day delay → email	Jan 2025	Feb 2025	Adam

This takes 5 minutes to set up and is invaluable when: - You need to troubleshoot a broken automation - You onboard a team member who needs to understand your stack - You're changing tools and need to know what needs to be re-connected

Seasonal and One-Off Maintenance

End of financial year: - Review all payment reminder sequences and clear out any long-overdue invoices that have been resolved - Update your P&L report automation for the new financial year date ranges - Check that GST/tax settings in your accounting integrations are still correct

When you change email providers: - Re-authenticate every automation that sends emails - Update the “From” address in all email templates - Test every email-sending automation

When you add a new product line: - Add the new products to your inventory reorder monitoring - Update your weekly report if you want the new category tracked - Check that fulfilment automations handle the new product type correctly

When you hire staff: - Review who receives which notifications - Add new team members to relevant Slack channels that automation posts to - Consider building an onboarding automation (new employee → account creation + welcome email sequence)

When to Call in Help

Sometimes an automation breaks in a way that’s beyond a simple fix. Here are the signs you should reach out to a specialist (like us at Ignition Agency):

- An automation has been broken for more than 48 hours and you can’t identify the cause
- You want to build something more complex than the recipes in this book
- Your business has grown and your current stack is no longer adequate
- You’re hitting task limits and need to either optimise or upgrade
- You want to add AI capabilities to your existing automations

A good automation specialist can diagnose most issues in 15–30 minutes and save you hours of frustration.

PART NINE: BONUS

Automation Audit Worksheet

Assess Your Current Manual Tasks and Identify Your Automation Priorities

This worksheet is designed to help you systematically identify every manual process in your business that's a candidate for automation. Set aside 30 minutes with a coffee and work through it honestly.

Section 1: Task Inventory

Go through each of these common business areas and tick every task you currently do manually.

📩 **Lead Management** - [ ] Enter new leads from website forms into CRM - [ ] Assign leads to team members - [ ] Send initial response to new enquiries - [ ] Follow up on enquiries that haven't responded - [ ] Update lead status after a call or meeting - [ ] Other: _____

📦 **Orders & Fulfilment** - [ ] Notify warehouse/fulfilment team of new orders - [ ] Update order status in spreadsheet - [ ] Send shipping confirmations to customers - [ ] Process returns and refunds - [ ] Create and email invoices for orders - [ ] Other: _____

💬 **Customer Communications** - [ ] Send welcome emails to new customers - [ ] Follow up after a purchase - [ ] Request reviews after delivery - [ ] Respond to common enquiries - [ ] Send birthday/anniversary messages - [ ] Other: _____

💰 **Finance & Admin** - [ ] Create and send invoices - [ ] Chase overdue payments - [ ] Reconcile transactions in accounting software - [ ] Pull monthly P&L for accountant - [ ] Track expenses - [ ] Other: _____

📊 **Reporting** - [ ] Compile weekly sales report - [ ] Pull Google Analytics data - [ ] Create end-of-month financial summary - [ ] Track KPIs across multiple platforms - [ ] Other: _____

📦 **Inventory & Purchasing** - [ ] Monitor stock levels - [ ] Identify products approaching reorder point - [ ] Create and send purchase orders - [ ] Update inventory quantities after receiving stock - [ ] Other: _____

📅 **Scheduling & Bookings** - [ ] Respond to meeting requests - [ ] Send meeting confirmations - [ ] Send meeting reminders - [ ] Follow up after meetings - [ ] Other: _____

📣 **Marketing & Social** - [ ] Monitor social media for brand mentions - [ ] Post to social media - [ ] Send marketing emails - [ ] Track competitor activity - [ ] Other: _____

Section 2: Priority Scoring

For each task you ticked above, fill in this table:

TASK	TIMES/ WEEK	MINUTES EACH	TOTAL HRS/WEEK	PAIN (1-5)	SCORE

Score = (Total hrs/week × 10) + (Pain × 2) Rank your list by score, highest first.

Section 3: Your Top 3 Automation Priorities

Based on your scores, what are your top 3 automation priorities?

#1 Priority: _____

- Current time cost per week: _____ hours
- Estimated time saved with automation: _____ hours
- Relevant recipe in this playbook: _____
- Target implementation date: _____

#2 Priority: _____

- Current time cost per week: _____ hours
- Estimated time saved with automation: _____ hours
- Relevant recipe in this playbook: _____
- Target implementation date: _____

#3 Priority: _____

- Current time cost per week: _____ hours
- Estimated time saved with automation: _____ hours
- Relevant recipe in this playbook: _____
- Target implementation date: _____

Section 4: Your Current Tech Stack Audit

Understanding what you already have helps identify the easiest integration paths.

Do you currently use:

CRM: - [ ] HubSpot - [ ] Salesforce - [ ] Pipedrive - [ ] Monday.com - [ ] Notion - [ ] Spreadsheet (manual) - [ ] No CRM - [ ] Other: _____

E-commerce: - [ ] Shopify - [ ] WooCommerce - [ ] BigCommerce - [ ] Squarespace - [ ] No online store - [ ] Other: _____

Accounting: - [ ] Xero - [ ] MYOB - [ ] QuickBooks - [ ] Wave (free) - [ ] Spreadsheet (manual) - [ ] Other: _____

Communication: - [ ] Slack - [ ] Microsoft Teams - [ ] Gmail / Google Workspace - [ ] Microsoft 365 - [ ] Other: _____

Forms: - [ ] Gravity Forms (WordPress) - [ ] Typeform - [ ] Jotform - [ ] Google Forms - [ ] Contact Form 7 - [ ] Other: _____

Booking: - [ ] Calendly - [ ] Cal.com - [ ] Acuity Scheduling - [ ] No booking tool - [ ] Other: _____

Email Marketing: - [ ] Mailchimp - [ ] Klaviyo - [ ] ActiveCampaign - [ ] HubSpot Email - [ ] None - [ ] Other: _____

Section 5: Your Automation Roadmap

Based on what you've found above, fill in your 90-day automation roadmap:

Days 1–14 (Quick Wins): 1. _____ 2. _____

Days 15–30 (Core Infrastructure): 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

Days 31–60 (Advanced Automations): 1. _____ 2. _____

Days 61–90 (Optimise and Expand): 1. _____ 2. _____

Section 6: ROI Projection

Fill this in after completing your audit:

AUTOMATION	TIME SAVED/WEEK	HOURS × RATE	ANNUAL VALUE
	hrs	× $	$
	hrs	× $	$
	hrs	× $	$
	hrs	× $	$
	hrs	× $	$
Total			**$**

Monthly automation stack cost: $_____ **Monthly value of time saved:** $_____ **ROI:** _____x

For most businesses, the ROI is 5–20x. If yours is below 3x, you're either undervaluing your time or picking the wrong automations to prioritise.

PART TEN: NEXT STEPS

You've Got the Blueprint. Now Execute.

Let's bring it home.

You've just been handed a complete automation strategy — 10 battle-tested recipes, a tool comparison, a budget framework, and a worksheet to find your biggest opportunities. This isn't theory. These are working automations running inside Australian businesses right now.

But knowledge without action is just expensive reading.

Here's what to do in the next 48 hours:

Your 48-Hour Action Plan

Today (first 30 minutes): 1. Complete the Automation Audit Worksheet in Part 9 2. Identify your top 3 priorities 3. Sign up for Zapier (free) if you haven't already 4. Pick Recipe #1 or Recipe #7 — they're the easiest starting points

Today (next 60 minutes): 1. Follow the beginner walkthrough in Part 5 2. Build and test your first automation 3. Turn it on

Tomorrow: 1. Confirm your first automation ran correctly (check the task history) 2. Start reading the recipe for your #2 priority 3. Build it

Within the week: 1. Have all 3 of your priority automations live 2. Set up your monthly maintenance checklist (put it in your calendar) 3. Document your automations in your register

If you hit a wall at any point — that's normal. Most people get stuck on credential connections (Step 3 of most recipes) or data mapping. Both are fixable in 10 minutes with the right help.

What Comes After the 10 Recipes?

Once you've got these running, there's a whole next level of automation available to you:

AI-Powered Automations Adding GPT or Claude to your workflows transforms them from data movers to intelligent assistants. AI can write first-draft responses, score leads, summarise reports, and make routing decisions. All of this is accessible today via the same platforms you're already using.

Multi-Step Marketing Sequences Beyond the single review request email, you can build full nurture sequences: lead magnet delivery → education series → offer → follow-up. Tools like Klaviyo or ActiveCampaign, connected to Make or n8n, make this possible without a developer.

Internal Operations Automation Onboarding new staff, managing project kick-offs, tracking job progress, generating quotes — there's an automation for every operational workflow in your business.

Customer Lifecycle Automation Winning back churned customers, identifying your best customers and triggering a VIP experience, detecting churn risk early — all automatable with the right data connections.

We'd love to help you get there.

🚀 Free 30-Minute Automation Audit — Ignition Agency

We're Ignition Agency, and we live and breathe business automation.

We work with Australian small and medium businesses to design, build, and maintain automation stacks that save hundreds of hours per year — and we do it without jargon, without enterprise pricing, and without making you feel stupid for not knowing this stuff already.

What You'll Get in Your Free 30-Minute Automation Audit

In 30 minutes on a Zoom call, we will:

✅ **Review your current tech stack** — what you're using, what's connected, what's not

✅ **Identify your top 3 automation opportunities** — based on your specific business, not a generic framework

✅ **Show you live examples** — real automations in businesses similar to yours

✅ **Give you a clear next-step plan** — even if you choose to implement it yourself

✅ **Answer every question you have** — no sales pressure, no upsell agenda

This is genuinely free. No credit card. No obligation. If you like what you hear and want our help to implement it, we'll talk about that. If not, you leave with a better plan than you came in with.

Who This Is For

- Small business owners who know they should be automating more but don't know where to start
- Business owners who've tried automation but couldn't get it to work reliably
- Growing businesses whose manual processes are starting to limit their scale
- Anyone who read this playbook and wants expert help implementing it

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Book Your Free Audit

👉 **ignitionagency.au/automation-audit**

Or email us directly: **hello@ignitionagency.au**

We're based in Australia, we work across all time zones, and we typically have audit slots available within 2–3 business days.

A Personal Note

If you've read this far, you're already ahead of most business owners. Most people buy stuff like this and never open it. You read it.

Now do something with it.

The businesses that win over the next five years will be the ones that use software to do the work that doesn't need a human — so the humans can focus on the work that does. Relationships. Strategy. Creativity. Service.

That's where your energy belongs. Not in spreadsheets and data entry.

You've got the recipes. You've got the tools. You know the path.

We're here if you need a guide.

— The Ignition Agency Team 🌐 ignitionagency.au 📧 hello@ignitionagency.au

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Quick Reference Card

The 10 Automations at a Glance

#	AUTOMATION	TIME SAVED/WEEK	DIFFICULTY	BEST TOOL
1	Lead Capture → CRM	1–3 hrs	⭐ Easy	Zapier / Make
2	New Order → Fulfilment	30–60 min	⭐ Easy	Zapier / Make
3	Weekly Report → Email	30–90 min	⭐⭐⭐ Med	Make / n8n
4	Review Request	30–60 min	⭐⭐ Easy-Med	Make / Klaviyo
5	Invoice → Payment Reminder	30–60 min	⭐⭐ Easy-Med	Xero native / Make
6	Social Mention → Alert	30 min	⭐⭐⭐ Med	Make / Zapier
7	Inquiry → Instant Response	30–60 min	⭐⭐ Easy-Med	Zapier / Make
8	Inventory Low → Supplier Email	1–2 hrs	⭐⭐⭐ Med	Make / n8n
9	P&L → Accountant Delivery	1–2 hrs	⭐⭐⭐ Med	Xero / Make
10	Competitor Price → Alert	30–60 min	⭐⭐⭐⭐ Adv	n8n / Visualping

Total potential time savings: 6–13 hours per week

Platform Quick Pick

YOUR SITUATION	USE THIS PLATFORM
Never automated before	Zapier
Want more power, lower cost	Make
Technical comfort, want control	n8n (self-hosted)
Want AI built in	n8n or Make

Emergency Contacts for Broken Automations

- **Zapier status:** status.zapier.com
- **Make status:** status.make.com
- **n8n support:** community.n8n.io
- **Us:** hello@ignitionagency.au

Thanks for reading. Now go automate something.

🐾